

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

EMIL JONES III TRIAL

Jury hears alleged bribe

Ex-red-light camera executive asked state senator for ‘number’

By Jason Meisner and Caroline Kubzansky
Chicago Tribune

Democratic state Sen. Emil Jones III was digging into a big file at his favorite downtown steak joint in July 2019 when his dinner companion, a red-light camera company executive, brought up Jones’ upcoming fundraiser at Sox Park.

“How much money you want me to come up with?” SafeSpeed LLC co-founder Omar Maani asked over the soft steakhouse din. “You tell me a number.”

Jones initially demurred, telling Maani no one had ever asked him that before. But Maani explained he was different, that he always wanted to meet expectations.

“You’re already meeting expectations, Omar,” Jones said, cutting into his steak while a hidden camera sat somewhere on the table across from him. “You’re a good guy. I like you all’s company a lot.”

Then Jones dropped the number: “If you can raise me five grand, that’d be good.”

“Done,” Maani replied quickly.

That conversation, which Maani secretly recorded for the FBI, was the focal point of a long first day of trial for Jones, the son of former Senate President Emil Jones Jr. Jones III is accused of agreeing to accept bribes from Maani in exchange for his help tamping down anti-red-light camera legislation in Springfield.

Maani, the star prosecution witness, testified for the first time in a federal courtroom Wednesday that his company routinely sought to influence elected officials with campaign cash, dinners and cigars to secure more business.

“We would cut deals with legislators for financial support,” said Maani, who

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Stock markets soar after president announces 90-day pause for most nations

Import taxes on China, however, raised to 125%, signaling more drama ahead

TRUMP RETREATS ON SOME TARIFFS



A container ship is escorted into the Port of Oakland on Wednesday in Oakland, California. President Donald Trump announced a 90-day pause on some tariffs for all countries except China as the global trade war continues. JUSTIN SULLIVAN/GETTY

By Josh Boak
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — Facing a global market meltdown, President Donald Trump on Wednesday abruptly backed down on his tariffs on most nations for 90 days, but raised the tax rate on Chinese imports to 125%.

It was seemingly an attempt to narrow what had been an unprecedented trade war between the U.S. and most of the world to a showdown between the U.S. and China, but the drama over Trump’s tariffs is far from over as the administration prepares to engage in country-by-country negotiations. In the meantime,

countries subject to the pause will now be tariffed at 10%.

Stocks surged to one of their biggest gains since World War II after Trump declared a halt, as investors had desperately hoped he would.

After sinking earlier in the day, the S&P 500 was up 9.5%. The Dow Jones Industrial Average shot up nearly 3,000 points, erasing an earlier loss of nearly 370 points. The Nasdaq composite was 12.2% higher, a gain that would count as a good year for the broad stock market.

The global economy appeared to be in open rebellion against Trump’s tariffs as they took effect early Wednesday, a signal that the

U.S. president was not immune from market pressures. By early afternoon, Trump posted on Truth Social that because “more than 75 Countries” had reached out to the U.S. government for trade talks and have not retaliated in a meaningful way “I have authorized a 90 day PAUSE, and a substantially lowered Reciprocal Tariff during this period, of 10%, also effective immediately.”

The president later told reporters that he pulled back on many global tariffs — but not on China — because people were “yippy,” and “afraid,” adding that while he expected to reach deals that

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10% RATE INCREASE REMAINS: The 10% tariff was the baseline rate for most nations that went into effect on Saturday. It’s meaningfully lower than the 20% tariff that Trump had set for goods from the European Union, 24% on imports from Japan and 25% on products from South Korea. Still, 10% would represent an increase in the tariffs previously charged by the U.S. government.

INSIDE: Economists fault Trump for tying trade gap, tariffs. **Business, Page 2**

Professors urge NU to fight freeze on funding

White House says it will withhold \$790M

By Nell Salzman, Caroline Kubzansky and Lisa Schencker
Chicago Tribune

Northwestern University professor Luis Amaral said President Donald Trump’s decision to slash hundreds of millions in federal funding from his institution is reminiscent of the 48-year dictatorship that gripped his home country, Portugal.

“People were attacked, they were tortured, they tried to travel away from the country. They were arrested. I’m seeing all of this happening once again here in the U.S.,” said the engineering and applied math researcher.

In a statement to the Tribune Wednesday morning, White House officials confirmed



Northwestern University President Michael Schill attends a faculty meeting Wednesday at which a packet of letters was delivered from law professors, legal organizations and alumni across the country asking the university to take a stand against the federal government. ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Trump’s plans to freeze \$790 million in federal funding to Northwestern. A White House spokesman pointed to a social media post by Pat Ward, senior White House editorial producer at Fox News Channel, explaining the cuts.

“The money was frozen in connection with several ongoing, credible, and concerning Title VI investigations,” Ward wrote in his post on X, formerly known as Twitter.

The news coincided with a

New York Times report that the Trump administration had frozen \$1 billion in federal dollars to Cornell University. Once the funding cuts were confirmed Wednesday morning, Northwestern did not respond to a request for further comment on which specific programs and departments would be impacted.

Federal dollars fund “innovative and life-saving research” at Northwestern and the school

Turn to Freeze, Page 4

White House revokes visas from students at some of the state’s top universities

By Carolyn Stein and Zareen Syed
Chicago Tribune

The state’s top universities, including the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign, Northwestern University and the University of Chicago, confirmed Wednesday that visas of international students were revoked by the Trump administration, joining a growing number of international students across the country who have had their visas canceled.

Officials say that many if not all have been revoked with no explanation and no prior notice, creating confusion on campuses and deep-rooted fear among students.

On Wednesday, U. of C. offi-

cials confirmed that the federal government terminated the F-1 visas for three current students and four recent graduates, while their Student and Exchange Visitor Program (SEVIS) status had also been terminated.

Meanwhile Southern Illinois University Edwardsville confirmed eight of its international students had their visas canceled, including three enrolled undergraduate students and five graduate students on optional practical training.

Students from U. of I., University of Illinois Chicago, Northwestern and Southern Illinois University Carbondale also have had their visas terminated, according to officials from those

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“My understanding is that Trump promised mass deportations and the people you can find that are the easiest to identify are students.”

— Genevieve Lakier, a University of Chicago professor

TODAY’S WEATHER



High 48 Low 36

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 16

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
177th year No. 100 © Chicago Tribune

